

INTRODUCTION

LEADERSHIP FOR
THE 21ST CENTURY

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Today, I can say with a greater sense of confidence and pride that in the calendar of ideas, the INDIA TODAY Conclave has become a much anticipated event. It has become a place where concepts collide, arguments provoke and ideas flourish. It brings together the best and the brightest, leaders and pioneers from every field of knowledge. It has become a project in tomorrow, sustained by INDIA TODAY's faith in the transformative powers of a questioning mind.

This year is no exception. We have a list of speakers who continue to breach the frontiers of their expertise. We have a programme that, I hope, will challenge the dead certainties of politics, business, science, spirituality and entertainment; that will engage your intellect and enrich your perception. Together, we have come a long way. As I look back, I realise, it has been a journey in history. And history, as I said last year, seems to have entered into a secret covenant with the Conclave. For me—and I'm sure for everyone who has participated before—it has been a journey that has made us wiser and a lot more optimistic.

It began six years ago, in the aftermath of 9/11, when the politics of fear ruled the world—and the politics of hate divided it. It was a rude awakening from the post-Cold War stupor. In retrospect, it provided a historical backdrop to the first INDIA TODAY Conclave. It is an understatement to say that the world has changed drastically since then. It is an altogether different matter whether our leadership has changed in same measure to deal with this world.

Fortunately, oblivious of the leadership changes, the Indian economy continues to roll on the fast track. And in the age of globalisation, India as a financial destination remains very much in vogue. As any global rich list will vindicate, India is fast emerging as the most fertile land of billionaires—as it is of the dispossessed as well, I must add. A volatile politics and a robust economy are matched by an outward-looking foreign policy. India, though rather belatedly, has begun to break out of the mindset of Third Worldism. Its engagement with the world has sought to strike a balance between national interest and international responsibility. It is a welcome change. Sadly, India is still home to the last custodians of a fossilised ideology—and they have the power to hold the government to ransom in the name of anti-imperialism. The last 'ism' of desperate revolutionaries who have nothing at stake except a few borrowed slogans. Ah well! Indian

